

New Quebec government will constrain Carney's decision-making

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【メール原文】

Quebec's new pro-independence government faces significant hurdles to another referendum but poses long-term political challenge for Prime Minister Ma|||||||

Quick take

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New Quebec government creates domestic challenge for Carney

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Short-term trajectory:

Long-term trajectory:

What Happened

The Parti Quebecois (PQ), the historic political vehicle for the Quebec independence movement, is projected to win a minority government in provincial elections held on 5 October 2026. PQ leader Paul St-Pierre Plamondon has pledged to hold an independence referendum during his first term as Premier of Quebec, but only after US President Donald Trump's term ends.

Our Take

A Quebec independence referendum is not imminent. The PQ looks likely to win less than 30% of the popular vote in a competitive multi-party race, and it will be constrained in a hung parliament. Support for independence is also at generational lows, with polling aggregator 338Canada.com showing opposition at 69% and only 31% in favor. The PQ therefore requires support from the far-left Quebec solidaire to hold a referendum, and it will need to cultivate "winning conditions" before it can feel confident, since a third loss for pro-independence forces—after defeats in 1980 and 1995—would be devastating. While Quebecois nationalism is a permanent feature of Canadian politics, the PQ victory had more to do with the first-past-the-post electoral system and rejecting an unpopular incumbent government than popular, grassroots support for secession.

Prime Minister Mark Carney nonetheless faces a long-term political challenge. The new PQ government will seek every opportunity to build its case for independence. That means picking fights with Ottawa—on issues such as immigration, culture, energy, the environment, and federal jurisdiction—that it can present as evidence that predominantly French-speaking Quebec would be better off as an independent state. Carney's decision-making will be shaped by the need to maintain support in Quebec, where his approval rating is high and Liberal Party holds 44 of the province's 78 seats in the federal House of Commons. His government, which includes several key cabinet ministers and senior officials from Quebec, will be seized by the political imperative of defending Canadian federalism against a reinvigorated separatist movement.

Provinces are Carney's primary opposition. With a majority government, Carney faces few obstacles in Ottawa to the enactment of his agenda (see: Carney's majority prompts long-term trajectory upgrade to neutral , 14 May 2026). However, Canada's provinces exercise considerable power, which they often wield against the federal government. The PQ's victory reflects that pattern. Voters could also use the Alberta referendum on 19 October, which will determine if the province holds a binding independence vote, to register discontent with Ottawa (see: Alberta referendum could entrench secessionist movement , 4 May 2026). Meanwhile, if British Columbia elects a new conservative government on 24 October, it could deepen divisions between conservative-leaning Western Canada and the federal Liberal Party, with its base in Ontario and Quebec.

Graeme Thompson

Senior Analyst, Global Macro

+1 202.540.5137

thompson@eurasiagroup.net

EG Canada

canada@eurasiagroup.net

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